Hiša Franko hosted a series of dinners and masterclasses, introducing Slovenian cuisine. In 2023, Chef Rupert Blease of Michelin-starred Lord Stanley curated a modern European menu at The Chambers. Arun Sundararaj, director of Culinary Operations at the Taj Mahal Hotel, says, "The chefs create an alchemy that reflects both their roots and the inspiration they draw from India. These experiences are about creating memories and building relationships." Anupam Dasgupta, general manager, The Leela Palace, New Delhi, adds, "Hosting high-profile chefs positions India as a serious contender in the global fine-dining landscape. It demonstrates that the country is not just a hub for cultural heritage but also a destination for world-class dining."

The phenomenon is pan-India. Atul Kochhar conducted a series of culinary sessions in Mumbai in May 2024. Renowned for his progressive Indian cuisine, Chef Gaggan Anand hosted a 14-course dinner at JW Marriott Bengaluru Prestige Golfshire. The mastermind behind Michelin-starred Thai restaurants Le Du and Nusara, Chef Ton presented an exclusive Thai dining experience at ITC Royal Bengal in September 2024. Known for his strong Indian flavours, Michelin-starred Manjunath Mural hosted a pop-up event in Kolkata.

For chefs visiting India, the appeal goes beyond its famed spices. "Many chefs are surprised to learn that there's no singular 'Indian cuisine'. The diversity fascinates them and inspires them to incorporate Indian ingredients into their menus," explains Sanghvi.

Chef Dani García, who has three Michelin stars, was captivated by the Indian tandoor, taking a mini version back to Spain. Daniel Humm of Eleven Madison Park created a dosa-inspired dish, and Alain Passard explored India's farm-fresh produce and created dishes honouring local flavours.

For Indian chefs, these collaborations are not just about learning new skills but also redefining how Indian ingredients can be used. Chef Sundararaj recalls a technique learned from a visiting chef: "They used a siphon gun to foam batter for pakodas, inserted a frozen block of cured cream, and foamed it again. The result was a crispy exterior with a gooey centre. Techniques like these elevate our traditional culinary practices."

The price tags can range from Rs 25,000 to Rs 65,000 per head, but these events are not just about food for Indian diners—they offer an opportunity to indulge in world-class food without travelling. Despite the costs of flying in such renowned chefs, the elaborate staging of the events justifies the high prices. "Diners aren't just eating; they're transported to the chef's home restaurant, complete with façades and playlists, turning dining into a multisensory experience," says Raaj Sanghvi.

FOR INDIAN DINERS, THESE EVENTS OFFER AN OPPORTUNITY TO INDULGE IN WORLD-CLASS FOOD WITHOUT TRAVELLING

As India continues to host culinary legends, it not only redefines its gastronomic identity but also cements its place on the world stage. These experiences bridge cultures, inspire innovation and offer a taste of the future, positioning India as a powerhouse in the global fine-dining landscape. ■

–Satarupa Paul



JAREK PAJEWSKI

decade ago, I fell in love with Thai food, and now I'm bringing it home to India. It all came together when restaurateur Riyaaz Amlani and I met. Riyaaz handled the not-so-fun bureaucratic stuff, and I focused on the food. It's been a dream collaboration.

Q. What is the food at Banng all about?

Banng is all about showing how the Thais eat—family-style, with bold, vibrant flavours that celebrate the country's culinary diversity. During the R&D process, my team and I worked with Thai food masters like Hanuman Aspler and Supanat Khanarak to ensure authenticity. I'm a purist when it comes to Thai curries and stir-fries, so our curry pastes are freshly pounded in my Bangkok kitchen and flown to India twice a week.

Q. Is winning Michelin stars relevant and important for restaurants?

Yes and no. I know of restaurants that are not on any list but do phenomenally well. On the other hand, the Michelin guide or recognitions like that do so much to push a restaurant towards financial success. So, of course, it's relevant.

Q. What has the experience of being a judge on MasterChef India been like?

It's interesting, seeing contestants from little cities, even villages, and how they champion their own food and how much more Indian food has to offer than what we take to the world. ■

–with Amit Dixit